# Three Mistakes Families Make When They Plan Ahead for Dad's Care

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the habit that replaces it.

When a family plans ahead, the talk tends to go one of three ways: a forecast, a promise that nothing will change, or "let's see." All three come from caring about Dad, and each has an easier habit to put in its place.

## 1 Predicting a fixed path

**WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE** "First someone a few mornings a week, then assisted living, then a nursing home." A relative sets the stages out over Sunday lunch as if they were on a calendar, and the family starts debating the dates.

**WHY IT HAPPENS** A sequence feels like a plan, and a plan feels better than not knowing. But the National Institute on Aging says it can be difficult to predict how much or what type of care a person might need, and the Administration for Community Living says the duration and level of care vary from person to person and often change over time. [1] [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask a smaller question: what support does Dad need today? List the tasks in his week, what he does himself, what he gets a hand with and from whom. Date the page and leave the forecast off it.

## 2 Assuming the help at home can never change

**WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE** "He's fine. We've got it covered." And you have. You bring the groceries on Saturdays, a neighbor is home most days, and he still drives himself to the pharmacy. Nobody has said out loud that the arrangement counts on each of those.

**WHY IT HAPPENS** When something works, nobody wants to pick at it, and asking "what if" can feel disloyal to Dad. It isn't. The National Institute on Aging's advice about living at home as you age is to be realistic and plan to revisit the decision as your needs change over time. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask which changes you'd discuss with a professional. Write down what the arrangement counts on. Then ask his doctor which changes they'd want to hear about, and note who in the family would make the call. The page doesn't say anything will change. It says who you'd tell if it did.

## 3 Waiting to learn which capabilities might matter

**WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE** "We'll look into all that if we ever need to." The questions about what help would have to be able to do for Dad, at home or anywhere else, stay unwritten because nothing calls for them today.

**WHY IT HAPPENS** Looking into care can feel like deciding on it, so it gets put off. But the National Institute on Aging says the best time to think about long-term care is before you need it, because planning gives you and your family time to learn about the services available in your community. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Keep a short list headed Questions We'd Ask Then, and start it with this one: what capabilities might need a fresh look later? The Family Caregiver Alliance's questions for families include a close cousin: what types of help might be needed in the future? Write each as a question for a professional. Don't answer them, and don't attach a place or a date. [3]

**The one habit behind all three**

Write down today, with a date. Keep a list of who you'd ask and what you'd ask them. Leave what a change means, and what comes next, to the people who assess Dad.

**What this guide doesn't do**

It doesn't say what Dad needs, whether anything will change, or what a change would call for. It names three habits of thinking, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

## Ready for the next step?

You know which three assumptions to set down. The care interview puts a full record in their place: it asks about every area of Dad's daily life, including the ones that are fine right now, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

**Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›**

### WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The statements about predicting care, revisiting an arrangement and planning early, and the question about future help, come from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.


1. National Institute on Aging, What Is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources



From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.